



For Staff

Student Being Blackmailed Online

Responding to threats, coercion and blackmail online, from other students or from strangers, including threats to expose something a student has posted

Content Warning

This guide covers online blackmail and threats, intimate images, racist content and the risk of self-harm.

This is reference guidance, not a training course. Use it to check how to respond, or to prepare for a conversation. It does not replace the school's safeguarding training, policy or the DSL's advice on a specific case.

It contains descriptions of online blackmail and coercion of children, intimate images, a racist video, and references to self-harm and suicide (without any detail of methods). Some of it may be difficult to read, particularly if it connects with your own experience or that of someone close to you.

- You can read it in sections, take a break, or step away at any point.
- If this raises something personal, you can speak in confidence to your line manager, a senior colleague you trust, or the school's Employee Assistance Programme, if it has one, or **Education Support** (free, confidential, 24/7 on 08000 562 561). **Samaritans** is free and open any time, day or night, on 116 123.
- If you have a question about how this guidance applies to a situation you are dealing with, speak to your school's Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL).

If reading this makes you worried about a child now, do not wait until you have finished reading: speak to the DSL or a deputy straight away. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.

Immediate danger or possible risk to life: call 999 when it is needed, stay with the child, and summon the DSL or a deputy. Don't delay action to work through the steps. The 90-second Pause is for once immediate safety is secured, to stop an impulsive or investigative response. **Go to the Quick Reference Card.**

Why This Matters

Online blackmail uses something a young person fears being seen, such as an intimate image, a secret or something they once posted, to make them pay, send more, or do what they are told. It can come from organised offenders overseas, and it can come from another student. In 2025, the Internet Watch Foundation received **394 reports made through Report Remove in 2025** by UK children facing sextortion alone, an average of nine a week ([IWF, April 2026](#)), and the NCA's CEOP Safety Centre received 380 sextortion reports in 2024 ([NCA, 2025](#)). Research with young people shows that the person making threats can be someone they know, as well as a stranger ([NSPCC Learning, 2024](#)).

[KCSIE 2026](#) treats bullying, discriminatory behaviour including racism, and non-consensual sharing of nudes as child-on-child abuse (paragraph 37), and lists "sexual exploitation; coercion and threats" as forms of online sexual harassment (paragraph 540). Threats and coercion are safeguarding concerns, whoever makes them and whatever their reasons. A student who is being threatened, and a student who is making threats, both need a response today.

Scenario Overview

A Year 11 student tells you that someone has intimate photos of her and is demanding money, or more photos, or they will share them. She thinks it may be a boy from another school she has been messaging, but she isn't sure. This guide also includes a second worked example: a student who fears a video they once posted will be shared by another student to "out" them as racist.

What to Keep in Mind

- **A threat is a safeguarding concern**, whether it comes from a stranger or a student, and whatever the reason given for it. Tell the DSL **immediately**.
- **Ask about self-harm and suicide**. Blackmail causes intense fear and shame. Asking directly does not put the idea in someone's head (Samaritans).
- **Where intimate images are involved**: never view, copy, forward or delete them. The DSL follows UKCIS (in brief below; full detail in **Staff Guide 10** (nude and semi-nude images)).

- **Evidence: the DSL decides.** Students are never asked to collect, screenshot or forward anything, and you don't collect it either.
- **Everyone involved needs a response:** the student threatened, the student making threats, and anyone who has seen the content.
- If the offender appears to be a stranger demanding money, see **Staff Guide 88** (sextortion) as well.

How RESPOND Works in This Scenario

RESPOND is powered by **ACT: Active Intervention** (inaction is not neutral; "just ignore it" leaves the threat in place), **Contextual Safeguarding** (threats travel through group chats, friendship groups and followers) and **Trauma-Informed Practice** (fear and shame drive silence; connection before correction, even where a student has done something wrong). The steps work as a **helix**: see *The RESPOND Helix* section.

Step	RESPOND tool	In this scenario
● Recognise	4 Ps Context Scan	Who holds what, who is threatening, what is demanded, and by when
● Engage	The disclosure script; TED questions	No blame; ask about self-harm; look at nothing on the phone
● Support	Safety check first; "Your calm is contagious"	Risk to life, risk of the threat being carried out, safety between students
● Pause	90-second grounding; Three Lenses	Don't investigate, view, confront or promise
● Offer	Model alternatives; if in doubt, N before O	Don't pay, don't send more, stop contact, don't delete, tell
● Notify	DSL immediately; 999 for immediate danger	Blackmail or threats: the DSL now; the DSL decides about police
● Document	GOLD standard	Their words; what was threatened, demanded and by when

RESPOND is not a checklist to complete in order. Immediate danger or possible risk to life: act first (999 when needed, stay with the child, summon the DSL or a deputy), then return to the steps.

Need the essentials? The *Quick Reference Card* at the end of this guide covers the immediate response on one page.

The One Chance Rule: a disclosure may be a young person's only attempt to seek help. Make it count.



The RESPOND Helix: How the Steps Move

RESPOND is taught in a line, Recognise to Document, because sequence gives structure under pressure. In practice it moves as a helix. The first dimension is the steps themselves: you may loop back, hold at a step, or go straight to Notify. The second is time and severity: each turn sits higher as a concern develops. The third is context: a concern involving several children, places or platforms traces a wider spiral.

Relational and Systemic

For a child, safeguarding is **relational**: it happens through people they trust. For the adults around them, it is also **systemic**: the steps, records and shared decisions that make sure what a child tells one person reaches the people who can help.

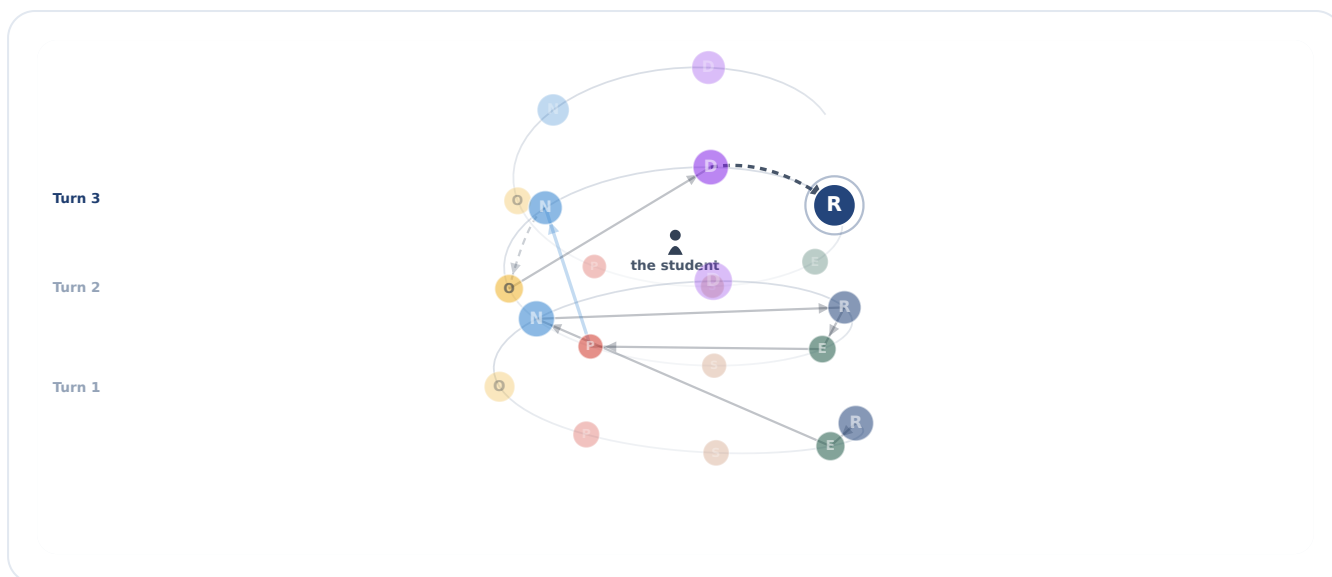
Relational is why children tell. Systemic is why telling works.

The RESPOND steps follow the same shape: Recognise, Engage and Support are relational; Pause is the bridge; Offer, Notify and Document are the systems steps. Neither works alone. Relationship without the system becomes secrecy, which is why staff never promise to keep a disclosure to themselves. The system without relationship becomes process that children do not trust enough to use. When you share information, be open with the child about what you are sharing and why.

See It Move

One example: threats with images, building over a week. Then see a wider spiral from the worked example, where a racist video, a threat to expose it and the students affected all move at once.

This is a still image of the interactive RESPOND Helix. Open the web version of this guide to step through the examples; every example is also written out in full below.



▼ Read the helix demonstration as text

Sequence

How RESPOND is taught.

1. **The seven steps:** RESPOND is taught in this order, Recognise to Document, because sequence gives structure under pressure. Recognise, Engage and Support are the relational steps; Pause is the bridge; Offer, Notify and Document are the systems steps.
2. **But practice is not a line:** Threats often build over days: a hint, then a demand, then a deadline. When there is blackmail or any risk to life, you go straight to Notify. Choose an example to see how the steps move.

Threats over a week

A Year 11 student is being pressured by someone who has intimate photos of her. The helix wraps around her.

1. **Turn 1: something is wrong:** A teacher notices she keeps checking her phone and asks a friend to lend her money. Recognise: the 4 Ps. You don't need a disclosure.
2. **Turn 1: Engage:** "You seem worried today. Tell me how things are." She says it's nothing. Tell her you're around, and that no problem is too embarrassing to bring to an adult.
3. **Turn 1: Notify:** pass the observation to the DSL the same day. The DSL may hold other pieces.
4. **Turn 2: the disclosure:** Two days later she tells you someone has her photos and wants £50 by Friday, or more photos, or they will go in the group chat.
5. **Turn 2: Engage:** the script. "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault. I'm going to help keep you safe, and I'll explain what happens next." Ask about self-harm. Look at nothing on her phone.
6. **Turn 2: hold:** Pause: 90 seconds. Don't contact the boy she suspects, and don't ask her friends to find out. Hold here on purpose.
7. **Turn 2: N before O:** Notify: the DSL, immediately. Blackmail with images means UKCIS applies and the police are involved.
8. **Turn 2: Offer,** once the DSL is involved: don't pay, don't send more, stop contact, don't delete, and let adults act. Explain what happens next.

9. **Turn 2:** Document: GOLD. Her words, the demand, the deadline; nothing about the images beyond that they exist.
10. **Turn 3: a new account:** A week later a new account messages her. Loop back to Recognise: a pattern helps explain, but nobody waited for it. Notify the DSL the same day, and Document, linked to the earlier records.

Wider spiral: the video

The worked example: a student who posted a racist video, a student threatening to share it, and the students who saw it. Three strands at once.

1. **Three strands:** One student fears exposure, one is making a threat, and others were hurt by the video. Each needs a response.
2. **At the same time:** Support the student who came forward, including a self-harm check. Pause before any contact with the student making the threat: the DSL plans that. Students hurt by the video are listened to.
3. **All to the DSL:** All three strands reach the DSL, who decides about the threat, the content, police advice and parents.
4. **Joined up:** Offer: education and repair for the video; boundaries and other ways to challenge racism for the threat; support for those affected.
5. **Every strand:** Every strand ends in Document, including the prejudice-based incident record.

The Helix is described in the RESPOND Safeguarding Operating System (section 5.2). All examples are fictional.

R

RECOGNISE: Identify the Threat and the Risk

Blackmail works by making a young person feel trapped and alone. Recognise what is being threatened, who holds the power, and how urgent the risk is.

The 4 Ps Context Scan

People

Another student, a group, a current or former partner, a stranger posing as a young person, an adult? Who else knows or has seen it?

Places

Where does it reach the student: school, home, the bus, the boarding house? Where will both students be today?

Platforms

Private messages, group chats, social media, gaming; fake or anonymous accounts; content saved or recorded without consent

Patterns

Deadlines, rising demands,
new accounts after blocking,
threats repeated to friends.
You don't need to wait for it
to happen again

What Online Blackmail and Coercion Can Look Like

Using Images

- Threats to share an intimate image, real, edited or AI-generated, unless the student pays, sends more or does something
- A partner or former partner using images to control who the student sees or what they do

Using Secrets or Past Posts

- Threats to share old posts, messages or videos, or to tell parents, friends or the school something
- Threats to "out" someone's sexuality or gender identity

Demands

- Money, gift cards, games credit or belongings
- More images, or sexual acts on camera
- Doing someone's work, carrying something, keeping quiet, or ending a friendship

Signs a Student May Be Being Threatened

- Sudden fear, panic or tearfulness linked to their phone; hiding the screen
- Asking to borrow money, or losing belongings; avoiding a particular student or place
- Withdrawal, falling attendance or attainment, tiredness from being on the phone at night

- Talk of being trapped, of everything being ruined, or of not seeing a way out

No Disclosure Needed

Many young people don't recognise what is happening, or feel too ashamed to tell: in NCA research with teenage boys, 73% did not know how to report sextortion (NCA, 2025). If you notice the signs, tell the DSL **without waiting for a disclosure**, and record what you saw and heard.

Threats, Blackmail and the Law (England and Wales)

One set of messages can be child-on-child abuse, a behaviour matter and a crime at once. Know the difference; leave the decisions to the DSL and the police.

What may be involved	What the law or guidance says
Blackmail	Making an unwarranted demand with menaces, with a view to gain or intent to cause loss (Theft Act 1968, section 21). The demand is often for money, but can be for something else.
Threatening to share an intimate image	An offence where the threat is meant to cause fear, or is reckless as to that. The prosecution does not have to prove the image exists (Sexual Offences Act 2003, section 66B, inserted by the Online Safety Act 2023).
Threatening communications	Sending a message that conveys a threat of death or serious harm, which includes serious financial loss, intending or reckless as to fear (Online Safety Act 2023, section 181).
Harassment	A course of conduct, meaning on at least two occasions, that alarms or distresses someone (Protection from Harassment Act 1997, section 7); grossly offensive messages sent to cause distress can also be an offence (Malicious Communications Act 1988, section 1).
Nude images of under-18s	Taking, making, sharing or possessing an indecent image of anyone under 18 is an offence, including computer-generated pseudo-photographs (Protection of Children Act 1978, section 1; Criminal Justice Act 1988, section 160).
Hate crime	Any offence can be prosecuted as a hate crime where it involves hostility based on race, religion, disability, sexual orientation or transgender identity (CPS).

Criminal responsibility in England and Wales starts at 10 (GOV.UK), and the CPS gives the age and maturity of young suspects "significant weight" (CPS). A threat from one student to another can be a crime, but it is always child-on-child abuse (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 37) and needs a safeguarding response either way.

Staff never decide whether an offence has been committed. Describe what you saw and heard, and report it to the DSL. Legal references checked 28 September 2026.

What the Data Shows

394

reports made through Report Remove in 2025 involved sextortion: 34% of confirmed cases, up from 23% in 2024

IWF, 2026

380

sextortion reports to the NCA's CEOP Safety Centre in 2024

NCA, 2025

74%

of teenage boys in NCA research did not fully understand what sextortion was

NCA, 2025

National figures cover sextortion reported to these services, not all online blackmail between young people, for which there is no reliable national measure. Checked 28 September 2026.

E

ENGAGE: Listen Without Blame

A student who is being blackmailed often believes they have caused it, and may be more afraid of adults finding out than of the person threatening them. Stay calm and believe them.

What a Student Might Say

"He's got pictures of me. He says if I don't send him money, or more pictures, he'll put them in the group chat. I don't even know if it's really him."

The RESPOND disclosure script:

"I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault. I'm going to help keep you safe, and I'll explain what happens next."

- **Thank them:** "Thank you for telling me. Coming to an adult is the right thing to do."
- **TED:** "Tell me what's been happening." "Explain what they've asked for, and by when." "Describe how you're feeling." Never "why".
- **Ask about self-harm:** "Some people feel so trapped by this they think about hurting themselves, or ending their life. Have you had thoughts like that?"
- **Look at nothing on the phone.** Don't take it, scroll it or ask to see images or messages.

Helpful

- "Whatever happened before, no one has the right to threaten you."

- "You don't have to pay, send anything, or reply."
- "We'll deal with the person doing this. You don't have to."

Unhelpful

- "Why did you send it in the first place?" (blame)
- "Just ignore them, they won't do it." (minimising)
- "Send me the messages so I can see." (never ask for content)
- "I'll speak to him now." (confronting can escalate it)

If a Friend or Bystander Tells You

Thank them, and use TED to find out whether the student is safe now. **Don't ask them to screenshot, forward, keep watching or find out who is responsible:** that is not their job, and sharing can spread the harm. If you see content being passed round on a phone, act **if it is safe to do so**, using the 4Ds, with Delegate first (get the DSL); don't take the phone to look.

S

SUPPORT: Safety First

Safety comes first: the student's safety now, the threat being carried out, and safety between students in school. Your calm is contagious.

Safety Check

Wellbeing

- "Are you thinking about hurting yourself?"
- "Who knows about this? Who is supporting you?"

The Threat

- "What have they said they'll do, and when?"
- "Will you see them today, in school or out of it?"

If There Is Any Risk to Life

Stay with the student and send another adult for the DSL. Don't ask about methods. Call 999 if their life may be at risk or they cannot keep themselves safe.

Immediate Practical Support

- A private space, with another adult nearby; time; the option not to go straight back to lessons
- Ask them not to reply, pay, send anything more, or delete anything
- Let them decide whether the phone stays switched off, put away or with them. Don't read it; the DSL decides whether a device needs to be secured
- If both students are in school, the DSL agrees immediate arrangements to keep them apart where needed, without announcing why

SEND, Neurodivergence and Language

- Some students may find it harder to recognise coercion, or may be targeted because of it. Use clear, concrete language and allow processing time.
- A student with SEND who is making threats may not fully understand the impact; the behaviour still needs addressing, with support.
- Use a professional interpreter where language is a barrier, never another student or a family member. Record adjustments.

Support for Everyone Involved

The DSL plans a response for each student.

The Student Threatened

- Safety planning, in school and online
- A named trusted adult and check-ins
- Mental health support where needed

The Student Making Threats

- A safeguarding response: what sits behind it?
- Clear boundaries and consequences
- Support to understand the harm

Bystanders who have seen content need reassurance that telling was right, and support if it was distressing.

P PAUSE: Consider Your Approach

Take 90 seconds: breathe, lower your shoulders, check your own state. The urge to confront the student responsible, or to see the evidence, is strong. Pause is where you stop.

Three Lenses

Lens	In this scenario
Risk	Is there a risk to life? Is the threat specific, with a deadline? Has anything been shared already? Is an adult, a partner or an organised group involved? Are both students in school today?
Rights	The right of the student threatened to be safe, believed and not blamed; the right of the student making threats, who is also a child, to a fair and safeguarding response
Resources	The DSL, the police, CEOP, Report Remove and Take It Down, Report Harmful Content, pastoral and mental health support, and families

What You Must Not Do

Don't Investigate or Confront

- Don't message the account, speak to the student suspected, or warn them off
- Don't ask other students who it is, or ask them to find out

- Confronting can lead to the threat being carried out and evidence deleted

Don't Collect or View Content

- **Never view, copy, forward or delete a nude or semi-nude image** (UKCIS; KCSIE 2026, paragraph 558)
- Don't photograph screens or ask for anything to be sent to you
- Only the headteacher, or staff they authorise, can search a student's device (DfE)

Don't Promise Secrecy or Outcomes

"I can't keep this between us, because I'm worried about your safety. I'll tell the DSL now, and only people who need to know. I'll tell you what's happening."

Evidence: Who Does What

- **The DSL decides** how evidence is preserved: for example, the family keeping messages, or a device going to the police.
- **You** record what you were told and what you saw, in words. You don't collect copies.
- **Students** are never asked to collect, screenshot, forward or save anything. Tell them: "Keep it. Don't delete. You don't need to save or screenshot anything: an adult can help."

Check Your Own Response

- Notice any judgement about a student who sent an image, or who posted something offensive. Neither removes their right to be safe
- Afterwards, look after yourself. Talk to the DSL or your line manager. Education Support: 08000 562 561, free, confidential, 24/7, for education staff.



OFFER: Model Alternatives

If in doubt, N before O: with blackmail or a threat, the DSL is involved before you offer options. Then explain what happens next, and model a different response to being threatened.

Explain What Happens Next

"Here's what happens now. I'm going to talk to our safeguarding lead, whose job is to keep you safe, and I'll stay with you. They'll decide what to do about the person threatening you, which may include the police. Please don't reply, pay or delete anything. Your parents or carers will usually need to know, and we'll talk with you about how. What questions do you have?"

Be honest about information sharing. Staff should share safeguarding information as early as possible, and data protection law does not prevent it; safeguarding children is a lawful basis for sharing sensitive information without consent where appropriate (KCSIE 2026, paragraphs 142 to 148). What is shared must be relevant, necessary and proportionate, go only to those who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. From 30 September 2026, the Information Sharing Duty (section 16LA, Children Act 2004) also requires the organisations it covers to share where its tests are met; the DSL decides how it applies. So don't ask for consent as if it were the legal basis. Tell the student what will be shared, with whom and why, unless that would increase the risk, and listen to their views: they shape the plan. Agreeing to a service, such as counselling, is a separate question, and their agreement matters there.

Options, Not Orders

- "Would you like me to stay while you talk to the DSL?"
- "How would you like your parents told?"
- "What would help you feel safe in school this week?"

Model the Alternative

What Helps

- Don't pay, and don't send anything more
- Stop contact; don't reply or bargain
- Keep it; don't delete
- Tell a trusted adult

- Block and report, once the DSL has agreed how evidence is kept, or now if that is what they need to feel safe

What Makes It Worse

- Paying or giving in, which usually leads to more demands
- Threatening back, or sharing something about them
- Asking friends to confront the person
- Deleting everything and saying nothing

Reporting and Removal (the DSL Decides Who Does What)

- **Police:** 101, or 999 if there is a risk to life or immediate danger.
- CEOP Safety Centre (National Crime Agency): ceop.police.uk, for reporting online sexual abuse, including sextortion. It cannot deal with bullying, fake accounts or hacking.
- Report Remove (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation): helps under-18s in the UK confidentially report a nude or sexual image or video of themselves so it can be removed or blocked online, at childline.org.uk.
- Take It Down (National Center for Missing & Exploited Children): available worldwide, including the UK, for images taken when someone was under 18. The image stays on the device; a digital fingerprint is shared with participating platforms only, so it cannot stop sharing everywhere (takeitdown.ncmec.org).
- Report Harmful Content (UK Safer Internet Centre): reportharmfulcontent.com, for anyone 13 or over in the UK (the DSL or a parent can report for a younger student), about threats, bullying and harassment and other harmful content, once it has been reported to the platform and at least 48 hours have passed. It cannot take reports of sexual images of under-18s.

Support in School and Beyond

- A named trusted adult; counselling or pastoral support
- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at childline.org.uk (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest)
- Shout: text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- Samaritans: 116 123, free, any time, day or night

- NHS 111, option 2, for urgent mental health help, any time, or NHS 111 online (nhs.uk)

N

NOTIFY: Report the Concern

Tell the DSL as soon as is practicably possible. With blackmail or threats, that means immediately. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.

Who and When

- Send a colleague or use the school's urgent system: "I need the DSL now. A student is being threatened online." Another adult stays with the student.
- If the DSL or a deputy is not available, go to a senior leader, or take advice from children's social care (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 61). Don't wait.
- Anyone can refer directly to children's social care or the police.

What to Tell the DSL

- Who the student is, where they are now, and who is with them
- Their words, including what they said when you asked about self-harm
- What is being threatened and demanded, any deadline, and whether anything has been shared or paid
- Who they think is responsible, as their words, not as fact; the platform and account name
- Whether intimate images are involved, and that you have not viewed anything

▼ For the DSL: assessment, external agencies and parents

Most staff need only: tell the DSL, today, with the information above.

The DSL's Initial Actions

- Assess any risk to life and agree the route to support, including NHS 111, option 2, for urgent mental health help, any time, or NHS 111 online (nhs.uk), or 999
- Where intimate images are involved, follow UKCIS: blackmail, coercion or an adult's involvement mean an immediate referral to the police and, where needed, children's social care (**Staff Guide 10** (nude and semi-nude images) has the full procedure; **Staff Guide 88** (sextortion) covers sextortion by strangers)

- Otherwise, decide whether to involve the police: for example, a demand with menaces, threats of serious harm, repeated harassment or hate crime. Take advice from the police if unsure
- Decide how evidence is preserved, following UKCIS and DfE searching guidance. No student collects evidence
- Plan safety between students, and the response to the student making threats under the child protection and behaviour policies, so that it does not increase the risk
- Where the police are involved, agree with them what is said to the other student's family, and when, before any contact (compare KCSIE 2026, paragraphs 599 and 603)
- Where the Information Sharing Duty applies (from 30 September 2026), apply its three tests: share information that is relevant to safeguarding or promoting the child's welfare (Relevance) and may help the recipient to safeguard or promote their welfare (May facilitate), unless sharing would be more detrimental to the child than not sharing (Detriment), which applies only in extremely limited circumstances; record the decision to share or not share, with the rationale, and be transparent with the young person unless that would increase the risk. Data protection law still applies to how information is shared
- Record on the safeguarding system, with a chronology, and set review dates

When to Involve Other Agencies

Agency	When
Police (999 or 101)	Blackmail; threats to share intimate images; threats of serious harm; harassment; hate crime; any immediate danger
CEOP (National Crime Agency)	Online sexual abuse, sextortion or grooming. Not for bullying, fake accounts or hacking
Children's social care	Significant harm or risk of it; exploitation; concerns about either student at home
Mental health services	Self-harm or suicide risk; 999 in an emergency
Report Harmful Content; Professionals Online Safety Helpline	Non-sexual content a platform has not removed; advice for staff

Where a Student Is 18

At 18 a student is legally an adult. The child safeguarding framework in KCSIE applies to under-18s, but the school still has welfare responsibilities. Where an 18-year-old is involved, the DSL considers adult safeguarding, police and welfare pathways alongside the

school's procedures, and the adult student's own views and consent in a different way. This matters in sixth form and in boarding, where students turn 18 during their final year.

Before Contacting Parents or Carers

Parents of each student will usually be told the same day. First consider whether telling them could increase the risk, for example a reaction to images or to something the student posted, or families contacting each other directly. Where it could, seek advice from children's social care or the police first. Where home may be part of the problem, the DSL thinks carefully about how, and whether, family is told.

Parent contact: the student threatened

- "We need to talk to you about [name]. Someone has been threatening them online, and [name] did the right thing by telling us. They're safe and with us now."
- "Please don't reply, pay, contact anyone you suspect, or post about it. Keep everything as it is."

Parent contact: the student making threats

- "We need to talk to you about [name]'s involvement in threats made to another student online. This is serious, and we are following our safeguarding and behaviour procedures."
- "We also want to understand what's going on for [name] and make sure they are supported. Please don't delete anything or contact the other family."

D

DOCUMENT: Record Observations

Record as soon as is practicably possible, on the school's safeguarding system, using GOLD. The police may use your record.

GOLD

Ground

Date, time, place, who was present, who you are, and how it came to your attention

Observe

What you saw and heard, with exact words in quotation marks

Language

Neutral, factual and non-diagnostic. No opinions or labels

Do

What you did, what you said would happen next, and why

Example: Exact Words

- Student said: "He said if I don't send £50 by Friday he'll put the pictures in the year group chat."
- Student said: "I think it's him, but the account doesn't have a name."
- When asked about self-harm, student said: "No, I just want it to stop."

Recording template

SAFEGUARDING CONCERN: ONLINE THREATS OR BLACKMAIL

Date and time:

Student: name, year, tutor group or house

Recorded by: name and role

How it came to your attention:

WHAT THE STUDENT SAID (exact words in quotation marks):

WHAT IS BEING THREATENED, AND WHAT IS DEMANDED (as described):

DEADLINES; ANYTHING ALREADY SHARED OR PAID (as described):

WHO THE STUDENT THINKS IS RESPONSIBLE (their words, not fact):

PLATFORM(S) AND ACCOUNT NAME(S), as told:

INTIMATE IMAGES INVOLVED? yes / no (never view, copy or describe one)

SELF-HARM: what I asked, and what the student said

OBSERVATIONS (presentation, emotional state):

WHAT I DID AND SAID (with times):

SHARED WITH: DSL (name, time, how)

THE STUDENT'S WISHES AND VIEWS:

Signed and dated:

What Not to Record

- Descriptions or copies of intimate images

- Guesses about who is responsible, stated as fact
- Opinions, such as "she brought it on herself" or "he's clearly a racist"

Worked Example: The Video and the Threat to Expose

A threat can come from a student who believes they are doing the right thing. The method still matters.

A Year 12 student tells their tutor they are really worried. Months ago they posted a video that some viewers said was racist. They realised, and took it down quickly. Now another student says they saved a copy and will share it to "out racist people".

Two concerns sit side by side, and **both need a safeguarding response**. Neither cancels out the other.

The Student Who Came Forward

- Is showing accountability by telling an adult. Thank them: telling was right
- Is being threatened, and may be frightened or ashamed. Ask about self-harm
- Still needs to understand the harm the video caused. Racism is not excused because it was taken down

The Student Threatening Exposure

- May believe they are standing up to racism, and may have been hurt by the video
- Is still making a threat, which is coercion and needs a safeguarding response
- Needs to hear that accountability happens through the school, not by public shaming

Step	In this example
● Recognise	Racist content is discriminatory behaviour; a threat to expose is coercion. Both are child-on-child abuse (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 37). Consider students who saw the video, especially those it targeted.
● Engage	"Thank you for telling me. Being threatened isn't OK, and we also need to talk about the video. Both things can be true." Don't minimise the video ("it probably wasn't that bad") or

Step	In this example
	punish them for telling ("you deserve it").
● Support	Ask about self-harm. Agree safety in school today, including between the two students.
● Pause	Don't ask to see the video, or ask anyone to send it. Don't speak to the other student yourself. Notice your own reaction to the content.
● Offer	If in doubt, N before O. Then: don't reply to or threaten the other student; don't try to get the copy deleted yourself; let the school deal with it.
● Notify	The DSL, the same day, and immediately if there is any risk to life. The DSL decides whether anyone needs to see the video, and whether police advice is needed about the threat or the content.
● Document	GOLD: their words about the video and the threat; no description of the content beyond what was said.

How the DSL Might Respond

- **The threat:** addressed with the student making it under the behaviour and child protection policies, with support to find other ways to challenge racism, such as reporting it to staff
- **The video:** addressed educationally, and under the behaviour policy: learning about its impact, and repair where appropriate and wanted by those harmed. Record it as a prejudice-based incident in line with school policy
- **The wider community:** support for students affected by the video, and for anyone who has seen it shared
- **Parents:** both families, planned so that it does not escalate between them
- **The law:** if the threat comes with a demand ("do this or I'll share it"), it may be blackmail (Theft Act 1968, section 21); without a demand it may still be harassment or a communications offence. The DSL takes police advice; staff don't decide



Nude Images: UKCIS

Where a nude or semi-nude image of an under-18 is involved, the DSL follows the UKCIS advice. Blackmail or coercion means an immediate referral to the police. **Staff Guide 10** (nude and semi-nude images) sets out the full UKCIS procedure; staff tell the DSL and never copy or share images.

Boarding and Residential Life

For boarders, school is also home. The student threatening them may be down the corridor.

Step	In boarding
● Recognise	The student making threats may live in the same house. Notice a boarder avoiding the common room or another boarder, or on their phone late at night.
● Engage	Boarders often tell house staff in the evening. Use TED and the script; talk somewhere visible, and let another adult know.
● Support	Safety tonight first: the DSL plans supervision, and arrangements between boarders, with the duty team.
● Pause	Don't search rooms or phones, or speak to the boarder suspected. Don't wait until morning if there is any risk.
● Offer	If in doubt, N before O. House expectations about group chats and sharing; older boarders as role models.
● Notify	The on-call DSL immediately where there may be immediate risk, including at night. Immediate danger: 999; out of hours, the emergency duty team.
● Document	Record on the safeguarding system before you go off duty, using GOLD.

Boarders' Routes to Help

- **Boarders can always contact their house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.** Make sure every boarder knows how.
- An independent person outside the staff whom boarders can contact directly (NMS 11.4), often called the independent listener
- Boarders must be able to contact their families privately; monitoring of communications should be proportionate (NMS 12.1)
- International boarders: agree with the DSL who contacts parents or guardians, when, and in what language, using interpreters where needed

Source: National Minimum Standards for Boarding Schools (2026).

Identity and Intersecting Harm

- **Race and racism:** racist content harms the students it targets, and KCSIE 2026 lists racism as child-on-child abuse. Responding to it through the school, not by exposure, protects everyone.
- **LGBTQ+ students** may be threatened with being outed, and may not want parents told why. The DSL considers this when planning parent contact.
- **Boys** are most often targeted by sextortion (IWF, 2026), and may worry about being judged if they ask for help. Girls are targeted too, sometimes with demands for images or sexual acts rather than money (NSPCC Learning, 2024); both need the same response.
- **Students with SEND** may be targeted, or drawn into threatening others without understanding the impact.
- **International students** may be threatened with contact to family abroad; use interpreters where needed.

Additional Resources and Support

For Students

- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at childline.org.uk (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest). **For under-18s, this is the place to start.**
- Report Remove (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation): helps under-18s in the UK confidentially report a nude or sexual image or video of themselves so it can be removed or blocked online, at childline.org.uk
- Shout: text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- Samaritans: 116 123, free, any time, day or night
- Internet Watch Foundation, *Sextortion or online blackmail: help for under-18s*

For Parents and Carers

- Internet Watch Foundation, *Advice for parents of children who are being 'sexorted' online*
- NSPCC Helpline: 0808 800 5000 (Monday to Friday 10am to 4pm), or help@nspcc.org.uk
- YoungMinds Parents Helpline: 0808 802 5544 (Monday, Thursday and Friday 9:30am to 4pm; Tuesday and Wednesday 9:30am to 6pm)

- NHS 111, option 2, for urgent mental health help, any time, or NHS 111 online (nhs.uk)

For Staff

- Education Support: 08000 562 561, free, confidential, 24/7, for education staff
- Professionals Online Safety Helpline (UK Safer Internet Centre):
helpline@saferinternet.org.uk, for anyone working with children
- NCA CEOP Education, *Financially motivated sexual extortion: alert for education settings* (listed in KCSIE 2026, Annex A)
- CEOP Safety Centre (National Crime Agency): ceop.police.uk, for reporting online sexual abuse, including sextortion. It cannot deal with bullying, fake accounts or hacking
- NSPCC Learning, *Young people's experiences of online sexual extortion or 'sextortion'* (September 2024)

Statutory Guidance and Law

- Department for Education, *Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026*
- HM Government, *Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026*
- Department for Education, *Information Sharing Duty: statutory guidance* (in force 30 September 2026)
- Department for Education, *RSHE statutory guidance* (published July 2025; statutory from September 2026)
- Department for Education, *National minimum standards for boarding schools* (2026)
- UKCIS, *Sharing nudes and semi-nudes: advice for education settings working with children and young people* (updated February 2024)
- Department for Education, *Searching, screening and confiscation* (guidance for schools)
- Theft Act 1968, section 21 (blackmail)
- Sexual Offences Act 2003, section 66B (sharing or threatening to share an intimate photograph or film; inserted by the Online Safety Act 2023)
- Protection of Children Act 1978, section 1 (indecent photographs of children)
- Criminal Justice Act 1988, section 160 (possession of indecent photograph of child)
- Online Safety Act 2023, section 181 (threatening communications)
- Protection from Harassment Act 1997, section 7 (course of conduct)
- Malicious Communications Act 1988, section 1
- Crown Prosecution Service, *Hate crime*
- GOV.UK, *Age of criminal responsibility*

Figures and Alerts

- Internet Watch Foundation, *Nine reports a week from UK children facing online sextortion* (7 April 2026)
- National Crime Agency, *NCA issues urgent warning about 'sextortion'* (29 April 2024)

- National Crime Agency, *Online campaign to tackle 'sextortion' among young teenage boys* (20 March 2025)
- National Center for Missing & Exploited Children, *Take It Down: frequently asked questions*

Contacts, figures and legal references checked 28 September 2026. Verify at point of use.

Quick Reference Card

Immediate Danger Comes First

Immediate danger or possible risk to life: call 999 when it is needed, stay with the child, and summon the DSL or a deputy. Don't delay action to work through the steps. The 90-second Pause is for once immediate safety is secured, to stop an impulsive or investigative response.

Recognise

- Threats to share images, secrets or posts; demands; deadlines
- From a student or a stranger, for any reason: always a safeguarding concern
- Fear around the phone; asking for money; talk of no way out
- No disclosure needed

Respond

- "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault."
- Ask about self-harm; stay with them
- Don't pay, don't send more, stop contact, don't delete, tell
- Never view images; students never collect evidence

Notify

- DSL immediately; another adult stays with the student
- Risk to life or immediate danger: 999
- The DSL leads on police, evidence, parents and both students; see the box below

Document

- GOLD: Ground, Observe, Language, Do
- Their words; the threat, the demand, the deadline
- Never describe an image

Emergency, DSL, Police: Three Different Things

- **Immediate danger or risk to life:** 999 now, stay with the student, then the DSL.
- **Every case:** the DSL, immediately. The DSL leads the response; you don't decide about police.
- **Police referral is not optional** where intimate images are involved and any of these apply: an adult is involved; the young person has been coerced, blackmailed or groomed, or there are concerns about their capacity to consent (for example, SEND); the content is unusual for their developmental stage, or violent; sexual acts and a child under 13; or immediate risk of harm, such as suicidal thoughts or self-harm. The DSL makes an immediate referral to the police and/or children's social care (UKCIS, section 2.3). Blackmail without images may still be a crime: the DSL takes police advice the same day.

Key Numbers

- Emergency: 999; police non-emergency: 101
- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest)
- Samaritans: 116 123, free, any time, day or night
- NHS 111, option 2, for urgent mental health help, any time, or NHS 111 online ([nhs.uk](https://www.nhs.uk))
- Your DSL: named in the school's safeguarding policy

Online Evidence: One Rule

- **Ordinary messages or posts a student has already shown you:** note what is relevant (platform, date, who, exact words) in your record. Don't ask to see more or scroll through a phone, especially where messages may be sexual, because they may contain images. Don't log in to accounts, search profiles or investigate, and never transfer anything to a personal device.

- **Nude or semi-nude images of anyone under 18:** don't intentionally view, copy, screenshot, forward, save or delete them. Tell the DSL straight away. If you see one by accident, tell the DSL, ask for support if you need it, and record that it was seen and what you did, without describing the image (UKCIS).
- The DSL decides what happens to devices and content.

Your School's Contacts

This guide is generic. Schools add their own details here, or keep a completed copy with this card, so that anyone responding, including at night, has the routes to hand.

Contact	Name and how to reach them
Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)	
Deputy DSL(s)	
Out-of-hours and boarding on-call safeguarding contact	
How to record a concern (system or form)	
Local authority children's services front door	
Out-of-hours emergency duty team	
LADO (concerns about adults)	
Police: 999 (emergency); 101 (non-emergency)	

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Reference Scenarios · Staff Guide 44

Scenario 44: Student Being Blackmailed Online

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Aligned with: KCSIE 2026 | Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026 | Information Sharing Duty (September 2026) | UKCIS Sharing nudes and semi-nudes (2024) | Theft Act 1968 | Sexual Offences Act 2003 | Online Safety Act 2023 | Protection from Harassment Act 1997 | RSHE statutory guidance (published July 2025; statutory from September 2026) | NMS for Boarding Schools 2026

Last Updated: September 2026 | Next Review: September 2027, or on publication of KCSIE 2027 if sooner

For staff in schools and other settings working with children. You may share it with colleagues. Share the student and parent guides, not this page, with students and families.